

BE NKY and Spirit of Construction Fund TradesNKY Programming

July 2025

BE NKY Growth Partnership and the Spirit of Construction Foundation announced investments into several Northern Kentucky education non-profit organizations at the Northern Kentucky Chamber of Commerce's Tuesday Eggs 'N Issues event, of which TradesNKY is one.

BE NKY, the economic development company for Boone, Kenton, and Campbell counties in Northern Kentucky, catalyzed the effort to generate new financial support for these organizations working with children and families from kindergarten to seniors in high school. BE NKY is investing \$200,000, with corresponding funding of \$220,000 from The Spirit of Construction Foundation, in TradesNKY.

- \$420,000, over fiscal years 2025 and 2026, with \$220,000 from BE NKY and \$200,000 from The Spirit of Construction Foundation, will fund an expansion of TradesNKY, a nonprofit promoting opportunities in the skilled trades that lead to successful careers. TradesNKY will help students in grades 6 – 8 explore trade careers in schools beyond Campbell County.

The Spirit of Construction Foundation, a coalition of individuals and companies committed to the construction industry's future growth and prosperity, is investing \$200,000 in TradesNKY, payable in two annual installments.

The organization is dedicated to fostering awareness of the importance of our region's construction industry and creating opportunities for young people and adults to thrive through careers in the industry and its various trades. The organization supports the construction industry through workforce development programs, community outreach grants and scholarships.

"With a focus on building it forward, we are invested in the growth of skilled trades and the construction industry as a whole in our region," said Spirit of Construction Executive Director Amanda Smith. "TradesNKY opens doors for young people in Northern Kentucky to discover many rewarding career opportunities in the trades."

These investments align with BE NKY's efforts to develop a comprehensive roadmap for workforce development by connecting students from kindergarten through 12th grades to Northern Kentucky career opportunities through exposure, exploration, and engagement.

In March 2024, BE NKY released “Population and Labor Force Trends and Future Projections,” a study researched by Janet Harrah and student fellows at the Center for Economic Analysis and Development (CEAD) at the Haile College of Business at Northern Kentucky University.

The study showed that although baseline projections predict a population increase of 58,429 people in Northern Kentucky between 2020-2050, the labor force in prime working ages of 16 to 64 is only predicted to grow by 8,450, highlighting the need to expand and upskill the region’s workforce.

Through subsequent meetings with more than 100 business executives at more than 40 strategic base companies, BE NKY learned that the number one challenge businesses were facing was the quantity and quality of the workforce available in the region.

BE NKY is focusing on students at schools where 50% or more of the students are in the free or reduced lunch program. This includes 26,876 students at 50 schools in Northern Kentucky.

“BE NKY is taking a hands-on, long-term approach to preparing our region’s children for future career opportunities at locally owned, national and international companies here in Northern Kentucky,” said BE NKY Growth Partnership CEO Lee Crume. “Our goal is for our children and grandchildren to have a deep understanding of the diverse corporate community we have in the region and the opportunities for good-paying jobs and career advancement they offer. We are looking for corporate partners who are willing to contribute financially and join us in classrooms throughout the region to reach children of all ages.

“TradesNKY is deeply grateful to BE NKY Growth Partnership and the Spirit of Construction Foundation for their unwavering commitment to workforce development in our region,” said TradesNKY Board Chair Phil Griffin. “Our mission to build a stronger future means investing in our young people today. These organizations understand that lasting change doesn’t come from a short-term fix, but from long-term solutions that empower the next generation with the skills and opportunities they need to thrive. We could not ask for better partners and we look forward to expanding our impact in the region.”

Today’s third graders will begin joining the workforce in just 10 years, and those who aren’t reading proficiently are four times less likely to graduate from high school by age 19, so it’s imperative to get involved with children’s education from a very early age.

Workforce issues are not exclusive to Northern Kentucky, but the collaboration and partnership among these six organizations, elected officials and other community leaders shows the region is dedicated to building a strong workforce for the future.

